Bajpai, who served as ambassador to the United States and also as foreign secretary narrated to the author that he joined the service because he was attracted to it even though his father (Girija Shankar Bajpai) wanted him to become a lawyer.[47] One of the lures of the Indian Foreign Service was the prospect of living in other countries and also to study in the world's elite universities. In his 2016 book *Choices: Inside the Making of India's Foreign Policy*, former foreign secretary Shivshankar Menon states that he joined the foreign service so that he could travel the world.[48]

Things have changed somewhat in terms of the calibre of recruits for the Indian Foreign Service, in particular, and India's civil services, in general, since the 1990s. The civil service no longer attracts the crème de la crème of Indian society as private sector jobs now offer higher pay and benefits. Indians can travel the world on their own, while doing other jobs, and do not need to be Indian Foreign Service officers to get that opportunity. There has also been a decline in those who joined the services, military or civilian, immediately after Independence out of patriotic motivations. None of this stops the Indian Foreign Service from considering itself an elite within India's elite bureaucracy.

After selection through a highly competitive national exam, Indian Foreign Service officers consider themselves as being among India's best and the brightest. They often view foreign policy as the domain of the Ministry of External Affairs and not something to be left to the whims of capricious politicians. According to professional civil servants, the function of the MEA is to evolve, frame and implement policy. Despite the centrality of the prime minister and the PMO, the day-to-day conduct of foreign policy and routine administrative work remains with the MEA and its professionals. These officials serve as key institutional input providers.

The relationship between the political structure and the 'steel frame' puzzles observers of India's decision making. The question is often asked as to how professionals at the ministry know what issues to handle on their